

American Realism, Precisionism, Regionalism

American Realism (or Social Realism) was one of several strands to American Modernism that developed in the early 20th century. It depicted contemporary society, capturing feelings and textures, sometimes with underlying hints of the psychological tensions of modern life, as in the work of Edward Hopper and the Ashcan School. Precisionism, meanwhile, emerged after the First World War and reached its peak in the 1920s and early 1930s. The first indigenous modern art movement, it was a celebration of new American landscapes of skyscrapers, bridges and factories. Artists included Charles Sheeler (1883–1965) who produced meticulously detailed paintings and sharply focused photographs of factories and public buildings. Regionalists, in contrast, celebrated the quiet, hard-working lives of Americans living in small towns and the countryside, away from city life. They included Grant Wood (1892–1942) and Thomas Hart Benton (1889–1975). During the Great Depression of the 1930s, Regionalism was widely appreciated for its reassuring images of indomitable Americans.



Hopper, *Automat*, 1927